

Subsurface scattering

The way a game engine simulates light passing through semi-transparent objects, such as crystals or ice, is known as subsurface scattering

Motion blur

Games simulate the effect of a slow shutter capturing a moving object, thus creating a visual effect of the object being blurred

Good graphics... ...better prices

Kumar Jhuremalani

kumar.j@thinkdigit.com

For those who do not need the highest performing graphics system, but who use perhaps, semi-professional graphics, casual gaming or need an HTPC setup, we test lower cost range of graphics cards and explain how to find one that fits your needs

It's been over six months since we last tested graphic cards and this time around we have a treat for you.

This graphic card comparison test is specific to those who are on a budget of up to Rs. 7,000. However, these cards are not only for low-end applications – some of these entry level cards have been specifically created for HTPCs with a low profile PCB and passive cooling.

Also gamers need not worry as last year's high-end cards, from certain vendors, have dropped in price and NVIDIA and AMD chipsets such as the 9800GT and GTS250, and HD 4850, now fall into the price bracket of up to Rs. 7,000.

We've divided the cards into two categories based on price. The first being cards up to Rs. 5,000 and the other, Rs. 5,000 and above. Based on these categories we saw some really interesting results in the performance scores and also cooling performance from each group.

We were quite disappointed by one fact though, not a single one of the graphic cards we tested this time came bundled with a game. Surprisingly, a few of them came bundled with 3D Mark Vantage instead, giving a call to benchmarkers in the low-end segment.

There are a total of 31 cards in the first category, while the second category has a total of 15 cards.

We received a good number of cards from most vendors, and we have selected the most

important or representative of these to test.

HTPC/Low end cards (Up to Rs. 5,000)

With large screen LCD TV prices dropping, we're sure many of you have, at some point or the other, planned to build an HTPC which you could use for playing HD and Blu Ray content with ease, and at the same time play games. Normally, people purchase mini-ITX form factor motherboards or micro-ATX form factor motherboards. There are specific cabinets that take the mini-ITX motherboards and these don't have enough space for full height graphic cards. For this reason, cards such as the NVIDIA 8400GS and AMD's HD4350 have been created with half-height or low

